

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

QUINE AND STRAWSON - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper I Western Philosophy 11

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

PHILOSOPHY PAPER I | WESTERN PHILOSOPHY 11

QUINE AND STRAWSON

CRITIQUE OF EMPIRICISM - BASIC PARTICULARS AND PERSONS

ONE SHARED TARGET: classical empiricism - attacked from OPPOSITE ends (epistemology vs starting point)

QUINE (1908-2000)

Two Dogmas of Empiricism (1951)

- analytic / synthetic distinction falls (circle of synonymy)
- reductionism / verificationism falls
- confirmation holism - web of belief
- no statement is immune to revision
- Duhem-Quine; radical translation
- gavagai; indeterminacy of translation
- to be = value of a bound variable
- empiricism WITHOUT the dogmas

ANALYTIC/SYNTHETIC

distinction cannot be drawn

WEB OF BELIEF

corporate body, no immunity

STRAWSON (1919-2006)

Individuals (1959) - On Referring (1950)

- descriptive vs revisionary metaphysics
- basic particulars = material bodies
- one spatio-temporal framework
- identification / re-identification
- person = a PRIMITIVE concept
- M-predicates + P-predicates
- blocks dualism AND no-ownership
- presupposition (not Russell's assertion)
- critic of the empiricist starting point

BASIC PARTICULARS

material bodies, one space-time

PERSON = PRIMITIVE

M + P predicates, one subject

Quine REFORMS empiricism from within (holism); Strawson REJECTS its starting point (private sense-data)

Provenance discipline: Two Dogmas (1951); On What There Is (1948); Word and Object (1960); Individuals (1959); On Referring (1950); In Defence of a Dogma - Grice and Strawson - (1956).

Owens exactly 9 Western Philosophy PYQ parts, 2018-2025, with none in 2022. Two projects kept distinct.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 9 owner questions, with none in 2022 (two each in 2018 and 2021).
- Ownership discipline: questions primarily owned by Logical Positivism, Empiricism or Kant are kept separate even where they overlap conceptually with Quine's critique of empiricism; the two projects (Quine's critique of empiricism; Strawson's basic particulars and persons) are kept distinct.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: thesis -> named source / argument -> analysis -> objection/reply -> verdict, each closing with a "Why this earns marks" note.
- MCQs: 40 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 48, strict A-B-C-D rotation twelve times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Provenance discipline observed throughout (Two Dogmas 1951; On What There Is 1948; Word and Object 1960; Individuals 1959; On Referring 1950; In Defence of a Dogma - Grice and Strawson - 1956; Duhem 1906; quantum logic Birkhoff and von Neumann 1936, Putnam 1968).
- No current-affairs anchor is used (no verified development found 2026-02-19 to 2026-08-19); relevance is static and syllabus-driven.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the nine exact verified PYQs -> 40 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED SOURCE / EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION / REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 9 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Quine and Strawson own exactly 9 primary parts, with none in 2022 (two each in 2018 and 2021). Ownership discipline: questions primarily owned by Logical Positivism, Empiricism or Kant are kept strictly separate even where they overlap conceptually with Quine's critique of empiricism.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q1(e), 10 marks

Question: How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Strawson explains the person not as a compound of mind and body but as a **logically primitive concept** - the concept of a single subject to which we ascribe both bodily and mental predicates, and which is presupposed by, rather than assembled from, the concepts of a pure ego and a pure body (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

The predicate matrix. A person is that to which we ascribe both **M-predicates** - properties we also ascribe to mere material bodies ("weighs 70 kg", "is in the corner") - and **P-predicates** - states of consciousness and action ascribable only to persons ("is in pain", "believes that p", "is going for a walk"). The mark of a P-predicate is its **asymmetry**: it is ascribed to others on the basis of observed behaviour, but to oneself without observation or criteria.

The argument (self-ascription requires other-ascription). I can ascribe P-predicates to myself only if the same predicates are ascribable to others; to ascribe them to others I must identify others as single subjects of both M- and P-predicates. Hence the concept of such a subject - a person - is presupposed by the very possibility of self-ascription, and is therefore primitive.

Consequence. This blocks Cartesian dualism (two independent substances could not be the single subject our predicate-practice requires, and other minds would become unknowable) and the no-ownership theory (which cannot state its own claim without covertly reintroducing ownership).

Verdict. The person concept is the indispensable middle term between mind and body; treating either as prior mislocates the foundation.

Why this earns marks: it names the exact apparatus (primitive concept, M/P-predicates, self-ascription requiring other-ascription), draws the anti-Cartesian consequence, and dates the source - four disciplined moves that fill a 10-marker without padding.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q2(c), 15 marks

Question: How does Quine show that the notion of a priori knowledge as discussed by Kant is 'a metaphysical article of faith'? Give reasons for your answer.

Model solution

Thesis. Quine's charge that Kant's *a priori* is "a metaphysical article of faith" is the conclusion of three connected moves: there is no principled analytic/synthetic boundary; confirmation is holistic, so no statement is *a priori by nature*; and naturalism denies any first-philosophy standpoint from which the *a priori* could be certified. Kant's *a priori* therefore rests on an undischarged assumption - an article of faith.

Move 1 - the analytic/synthetic circle. Kant's synthetic *a priori* presupposes a clear analytic/synthetic distinction. In "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) Quine shows analyticity can be explained only through synonymy, definition, interchangeability *salva veritate*, necessity and semantic rules - each of which presupposes analyticity. The boundary cannot be drawn non-circularly, so the category on which Kant's *a priori* depends is unfounded.

Move 2 - holism. Because beliefs "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body" (the web of belief), *any* statement can be held true come what may, and none is immune to revision - even logic. So no belief is *a priori in its nature*; apparent apriority is only greater centrality in the web, a matter of degree, not of kind.

Move 3 - naturalism. Philosophy is continuous with science, not its *a priori* tribunal; there is no external vantage from which to guarantee *a priori* knowledge. To assert it is therefore to take on trust exactly what cannot be shown - "a metaphysical article of faith".

Objection and reply. Kant can respond that transcendental conditions of experience are not empirical hypotheses inside the web, so holistic revisability does not touch them (Strawson's descriptive-metaphysics reading protects a framework role). Quine's rejoinder: that reply reasserts a privileged non-empirical status which is precisely the article of faith in question.

Verdict. Quine succeeds against a *sharp* *a priori/a posteriori* boundary; what survives is a gradient of entrenchment, not a certified Kantian *a priori* - though whether *some* framework role escapes the web is the live residue (kept separate from the Kant paper's own defence).

Why this earns marks: it keeps the question Quine's (not a Kant exposition), runs all three mechanisms with exact terms and the 1951 dating, and closes on a graded verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q1(e), 10 marks

Question: Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.

Model solution

Thesis. Quine argues that the analytic/synthetic distinction cannot be drawn by any principled, **non-circular** criterion; every proposed explanation of "analytic" presupposes a notion from the same family. His conclusion is precise: not that no sentence *seems* analytic, but that there is no principled boundary marking a class of truths true *by meaning alone*.

The circle of meaning (reproduce it). (1) Analytic truths divide into logical truths and those reducible to logical truths by substituting **synonyms**; so analyticity needs **synonymy**. (2) Synonymy might be explained by **definition** - but a good definition *reports* an antecedent synonymy, so this is circular. (3) Or by **interchangeability salva veritate** - but

in an extensional language this over-generates (coextensive terms like "creature with a heart"/"creature with a kidney" interchange without being synonymous), and adding "necessarily" to fix it presupposes necessity, which for Quine is intelligible only via analyticity. (4) Or by semantic rules in an artificial language - but these merely list what is to count as analytic, without saying what analyticity is. Every road returns to the start.*

Analysis. The dogma survives only as an unexplained primitive; the appearance of analyticity is really only greater centrality in the web of belief - a difference of degree, not of kind.

Objection and reply. Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) argue that a distinction in ordinary use with agreed examples is not discredited merely because no reductive definition is available. Quine's reply: agreed examples do not supply the *principled behavioural boundary* the epistemology of logical empiricism required.

Verdict. Quine wins where the distinction was load-bearing (the verification principle, the linguistic theory of necessity); the exact result is the failure of a non-circular criterion, not the denial that "bachelors are unmarried" looks analytic.

Why this earns marks: it gives the closed circle step by step, states the precise (often-missed) conclusion, and answers the standard Grice-Strawson objection.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars.

Model solution

Thesis. For Strawson, **spatio-temporal thinking is a precondition of objective thinking itself**: we can think of a world of particulars that exist independently of our experience only because we can locate and re-locate them in a single public spatio-temporal framework - and material bodies, his basic particulars, are what constitute that framework (*Individuals*, 1959).

Objectivity and re-identification. Objective thought requires the distinction between "how things are" and "how they seem to me". That distinction has a use only if I can **re-identify** particulars - judge "this is the same one I encountered before" - across gaps in observation. Re-identification in turn requires a **single, unified system of space and time** within which a thing traces a continuous career.

Why material bodies are basic. Bodies are three-dimensional, relatively enduring and publicly located; they compose the one spatio-temporal system, and every more shadowy particular (a sound, a flash, a private sensation) is identified only by reference to bodies and their positions. So bodies are the **basic particulars** - identifiable without first identifying anything else - and spatio-temporal thinking is built into objective thought.

The no-space test. Strawson's purely **auditory world** asks whether a non-spatial being could sustain re-identification. His answer: only by constructing a sound-analogue of space (a "master-sound" whose pitch fixes position) - which *concedes* the thesis, since a space-substitute must be reintroduced.

Objection and reply. Evans and others argue the auditory construction may smuggle in spatial notions or fall short of genuine re-identification, and that a merely temporal framework might suffice. Reply: even the minimal construction must reintroduce something that plays space's *individuating* role, which is the substantive claim.

Verdict. Spatio-temporal thinking is not a convenient tool for finding things but a **transcendental condition** of there being objective particulars to think about; the dependence claim survives the objections.

Why this earns marks: it routes the general "objectivity" point through Strawson's own re-identification argument and auditory-world test, and evaluates rather than merely expounds.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2021 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Basic particulars are the particulars that can be **identified without first identifying anything else**; Strawson argues that **material bodies** and **persons** are the two basic categories, because both are required for the single public framework in which objective particular-identification is possible (*Individuals*, 1959).

Material bodies. Objective thought requires **re-identification** of particulars, which requires a **single, unified spatio-temporal system**; material bodies - three-dimensional, enduring, publicly located - constitute that system, and every other particular (events, processes, private experiences) is identified by reference to them. Hence bodies are basic. The **no-space (auditory) world** confirms this: re-identification without space is possible only by building a space-analogue.

Persons. Persons are the *second* basic particular because the concept of a person is **primitive** - a single subject of both **M-predicates** (also true of bodies) and **P-predicates** (states of consciousness, ascribed to others on behavioural criteria, to oneself without observation). Since **self-ascription of P-predicates requires other-ascription**, and other-ascription requires identifying others as embodied subjects, persons cannot be reduced to bodies-plus-egos; they are irreducibly basic.

Critical discussion. (i) Are persons genuinely *co-basic* with bodies, or dependent on them (since persons are a kind of body)? Strawson's answer: persons are not *reducible* to bodies because P-predicates cannot be analysed in purely bodily terms, so both categories are needed. (ii) Evans-type objections to the auditory world; (iii) whether the argument establishes *primitiveness* or only *co-instantiation* of the mental and bodily.

Verdict. The dual thesis holds: bodies ground the spatio-temporal framework, persons ground the subject of experience, and neither category can be dissolved into the other without losing the conditions of objective thought.

Why this earns marks: it defines "basic" precisely, argues bodies *and* persons with their distinct mechanisms (re-identification; primitiveness), and delivers the "critically discuss" demand with real objections.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q3(c), 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Model solution

Thesis. "Empiricism without the dogmas" is Quine's positive doctrine: once the two dogmas are abandoned, what remains is a **holistic empiricism** in which experience still governs belief, but the whole web of belief - not the individual sentence - faces the tribunal of experience (*Two Dogmas of Empiricism*, 1951).

The two dogmas removed. Dogma 1, the **analytic/synthetic distinction**, fails because "analytic" has no non-circular criterion (synonymy, definition, interchangeability *salva veritate*, necessity, semantic rules all presuppose it). Dogma 2, **reductionism** - the belief that each meaningful statement is equivalent to a construction upon terms referring to immediate experience, so that each has its own range of confirming experiences - fails because no statement is confirmed in isolation.

The positive residue - holism. Our beliefs form a **web** or "field of force" that impinges on experience only at its edges; a recalcitrant experience forces readjustment *somewhere*, but which statements to revise is **underdetermined** by experience, so "no statement is immune to revision" and "any statement can be held true come what may". This is the **Duhem-Quine** point: a hypothesis meets experience only conjoined with auxiliaries. Empiricism survives as the thesis that experience is the only check on belief; what is dropped is the atomistic idea that it checks sentences one by one.

Objection and reply. (i) Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) argue Quine has not shown the analytic/synthetic distinction is *unreal*, only undefined - so the residue may be an overreach. (ii) If any statement can be saved, does holism license irrationalism? Reply: revision is disciplined by pragmatic virtues - **minimum mutilation**, conservatism, simplicity - so holism is not "anything goes". (iii) Quine himself concedes we may keep speaking of centrality and periphery, which does much of the analytic/synthetic work by degree.

Verdict. The postulate is coherent and powerful: empiricism is *reformed*, not abandoned - experience governs the corporate body of belief holistically - but its cost is the loss of any sharp a priori/empirical line, replaced by gradients of entrenchment.

Why this earns marks: it explains *both* dogmas, isolates the exact positive residue (holism + pragmatic constraints), and critically examines it with the standard objections and a ruling.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Strawson considers **person** a *primitive* concept because it cannot be analysed as a composite of a pure Cartesian ego and a material body; rather, the concept of a single subject bearing both bodily and mental predicates is **logically prior** to, and presupposed by, both. Its chief implication is the collapse of mind-body dualism, since two independent substances could not be the one subject our predicate-practice demands (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3, "Persons").

1. What "primitive" means. To call the person concept primitive is to deny that it is *definable* in terms of the concept of a pure consciousness plus the concept of a body. Those two concepts are, for Strawson, *later abstractions* from the person concept, not its constituents; the Cartesian order of analysis is inverted.

2. The predicate matrix. We ascribe to one and the same individual both **M-predicates** (also true of mere bodies - "weighs 70 kg", "is in the room") and **P-predicates** (states of consciousness and action - "is in pain", "believes", "is going for a walk"). P-predicates are **asymmetric**: ascribed to others on behavioural criteria, to oneself without observation. That a single concept carries predicates of this double character is the central datum.

3. The self-ascription argument. (i) I ascribe P-predicates to myself. (ii) A predicate I ascribe to myself must be one I can ascribe to others. (iii) To ascribe P-predicates to others I must identify them as single subjects of both M- and P-predicates. (iv) Therefore the concept of such a subject - a person - is presupposed by self-ascription itself; it is primitive.

4. Implication for dualism. On dualism the real subject is an immaterial ego and the body a separate substance. Then P-predicates would attach to an ego I can never observe in others, so I could neither learn nor apply them - and so could not self-ascribe them either; and two logically independent substances could not be the *single* subject our practice requires. Dualism makes other minds unknowable and P-ascription unintelligible. **The mirror error - the no-ownership theory** (Lichtenberg's "it thinks" for Descartes's "I think") - is equally blocked: it cannot state that experiences depend on *this* body rather than that without covertly using "my", reintroducing the ownership it denies. So experiences are necessarily owned by a person.

5. Objections and reply. (i) Does the argument prove *primitiveness*, or only that the mental and bodily are *co-instantiated*? Strawson: mere co-instantiation would not explain the asymmetric logic of P-predicates, which requires a single subject-concept. (ii) Ayer defended a version of the no-ownership view; Strawson's self-reference point answers it. (iii) The behavioural-criteria premise risks logical behaviourism; Strawson insists behaviour is *critical evidence*, not the *meaning* of P-predicates.

Verdict. The person is the indispensable middle term between mind and body; dualism and no-ownership both fail because each denies the single subject that the logic of P-predicates presupposes. What survives even under the co-instantiation worry is that any adequate scheme must treat the person, not the ego or the body, as basic.

Why this earns marks: it delivers the full 20-mark architecture - define primitive, matrix, self-ascription argument, the block on *both* dualism and no-ownership, then named objections and a graded verdict - with the 1959 source.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2024 Q4(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Model solution

Thesis. The two dogmas Quine attacks in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) are (1) the belief in a fundamental **analytic/synthetic distinction**, and (2) **reductionism** - the belief that every meaningful statement is equivalent to some logical construction upon terms referring to immediate experience. Quine argues both are ill-founded and that they are "at root identical".

Dogma 1 - the analytic/synthetic distinction. The claim is that some truths are true *by meaning* (analytic) and others *by fact* (synthetic). Quine shows "analytic" can be explained only through a circle of interdefinable notions - **synonymy, definition, interchangeability salva veritate, necessity, semantic rules** - each presupposing analyticity. No non-circular criterion exists, so the distinction lacks the principled basis empiricism claimed for it. His precise conclusion is the absence of a boundary, not the denial that some sentences seem analytic.

Dogma 2 - reductionism. In its radical form (Locke, Hume, early Carnap's *Aufbau*) each statement has its *own* unique range of confirming or infirming experiences - **verificationism at the level of the individual sentence**. Quine argues no statement is confirmed in isolation: statements meet experience only in concert (the **Duhem-Quine point**), so the idea of statement-by-statement verification collapses.

Why the two dogmas are "at root identical". The analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism are two sides of one verificationist theory of meaning: an analytic statement is the limiting case of one confirmed "come what may" (empty confirmation-conditions), while reductionism assigns each synthetic statement its private confirmation-conditions. Reject individual verification and both the sharp analytic pole and the reductionist picture fall together.

Consequence - holism. What replaces them is **confirmation holism**: belief faces "the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body" (the web of belief), and no statement is immune to revision. This is "empiricism without the dogmas".

Verdict. The nature of the two dogmas is that both are unearned commitments of logical empiricism's theory of meaning; dismantling individual verificationism removes both at once and yields holism.

Why this earns marks: it identifies each dogma exactly, shows *why* Quine calls them identical (the shared verificationism), and lands the positive holistic consequence - the depth a bare "explain the two dogmas" answer usually misses.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2025 Q4(b), 15 marks

Question: "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Discuss this statement in the light of Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Model solution

Thesis. The quotation - "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere" - states Quine's **confirmation holism**: because belief confronts experience only as a whole, any statement can be retained under any evidence, provided compensating revisions are made elsewhere in the web (*Two Dogmas of Empiricism*, 1951).

The web of belief. Our beliefs form a **field of force** or web whose boundary conditions are experience. A conflict with experience occasions readjustment *somewhere in the interior*, but "the total field is so underdetermined by its boundary conditions ... that there is much latitude of choice as to what statements to re-evaluate". Hence **"no statement is immune to revision"**, and, conversely, any statement can be held true **"come what may"**.

Why it is true - the Duhem-Quine mechanism. A hypothesis H predicts an observation O only with auxiliaries A: (H & A) → O. If O fails, logic yields only NOT-(H & A) - *something* in the package is false, but not *which*. So one may always protect H by revising A (or even, at the extreme, by "pleading hallucination" or revising a law of logic). Refutation is never decisive against a single sentence; that is the exact ground of the quotation.

Consequences. (i) The analytic/synthetic distinction loses its point - apparent analyticity is just maximal centrality in the web. (ii) There is no sentence-by-sentence verification (the second dogma falls). (iii) The a priori becomes a matter of degree of entrenchment, not of kind.

Objection and reply. Does holism license irrationalism - if we may hold anything true, is theory-choice arbitrary?

Reply: revision is disciplined by **pragmatic virtues - minimum mutilation**, conservatism, simplicity, generality, fecundity. We *may* save any sentence, but at a rational *cost*; central logical laws are given up only under enormous pressure (cf. the debate over revising logic for quantum mechanics - Birkhoff and von Neumann 1936; Putnam 1968 - and Quine's caution about "change of subject"). So "any statement come what may" describes what is *logically possible*, constrained by what is *pragmatically reasonable*.

Verdict. The statement is not a licence for caprice but a precise consequence of holism: experience constrains the web globally, not sentence by sentence, so rational revision is a matter of balancing conservatism against simplicity across the whole system.

Why this earns marks: it decodes the quotation as holism, grounds it in the Duhem-Quine mechanism, draws the consequences, and defuses the "anything goes" objection with the pragmatic constraints and a clean verdict.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 48 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-40 are core coverage - four per subtopic across the ten subtopics; Questions 41-48 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 12 times.

MCQ 1

In the syllabus item "Quine and Strawson", which pairing correctly matches each philosopher to his project?

A. Quine - critique of empiricism; Strawson - theory of basic particulars and persons B. Quine - theory of basic particulars and persons; Strawson - critique of empiricism C. Both jointly propose a single naturalized theory of persons D. Quine - descriptive metaphysics; Strawson - naturalized epistemology

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Quine attacks empiricism from within ("Two Dogmas"); Strawson develops a descriptive metaphysics of basic particulars and persons. The two projects are kept distinct.

MCQ 2

What single target do Quine and Strawson share, despite their different methods?

A. Kant's transcendental idealism B. Classical / logical empiricism C. Hegelian absolute idealism D. Aristotelian substance metaphysics

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Both are critics of empiricism - Quine reforms it from within (holism), Strawson challenges its private-given starting point.

MCQ 3

Which statement best captures the methodological contrast between the two thinkers?

A. Both rely primarily on transcendental arguments B. Both are thoroughgoing naturalists C. Quine is a naturalist (philosophy continuous with science); Strawson is a descriptive metaphysician D. Quine is a descriptive metaphysician; Strawson is a naturalist

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Quine's method is naturalism; Strawson's is descriptive (as opposed to revisionary) metaphysics.

MCQ 4

The claim "Quine reforms empiricism from within while Strawson rejects its starting point" means that:

- A. Both abandon empiricism entirely and embrace rationalism
- B. Both take private sense-data as the basic given
- C. Quine denies that experience is any check on belief
- D. Quine keeps experience as the check but drops the two dogmas, whereas Strawson denies that the private given can be foundational

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Quine's residue is "empiricism without the dogmas"; Strawson holds the given is public (bodies, persons), not private sense-data.

MCQ 5

Quine's precise conclusion about the analytic/synthetic distinction is that:

- A. there is no principled, non-circular criterion marking off a class of analytic truths
- B. no sentence has ever appeared analytic to any competent speaker
- C. every sentence is analytic
- D. analyticity is simply identical with logical truth

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Quine denies a non-circular boundary, not the appearance of analyticity; logical truths are only one part of the alleged analytic class.

MCQ 6

Interchangeability salva veritate fails to define synonymy because:

- A. it is explicitly defined in terms of definition, which is circular
- B. in an extensional language it also links merely coextensive terms (e.g. "creature with a heart"/"creature with a kidney"), and restricting it with "necessarily" presupposes analyticity
- C. it cannot be expressed in any formal language
- D. it presupposes the indeterminacy of translation

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Extensional interchangeability over-generates; adding necessity to repair it reintroduces the very notion (analyticity) under analysis.

MCQ 7

Quine regards the appeal to "semantic rules" in an artificial language as inadequate because such rules:

- A. are internally self-contradictory
- B. cannot be written for any language
- C. merely stipulate which sentences are to count as analytic without explaining what analyticity is
- D. presuppose radical translation

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Listing analytic sentences by fiat specifies an extension, not the concept of analyticity.

MCQ 8

The Grice-Strawson reply "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) contends that:

- A. Quine conclusively proved the distinction to be unreal
- B. synonymy can be straightforwardly defined by interchangeability
- C. analyticity is identical with empirical verifiability
- D. a distinction with agreed use and clear examples is not discredited merely by the absence of a reductive definition

Correct answer: D

Explanation: They defend the distinction's reality via ordinary use; Quine replies this lacks the principled behavioural boundary logical empiricism required.

MCQ 9

The second dogma, reductionism, is the belief that:

- A. each meaningful statement is equivalent to a logical construction upon terms referring to immediate experience, with its own range of confirming experiences
B. all statements are analytic
C. the meaning of a word is its use in the language
D. reference is inscrutable

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Radical reductionism is individual verificationism: each sentence is assigned its own private confirmation-conditions.

MCQ 10

In Quine's metaphor, the "web of belief" meets experience:

- A. sentence by sentence, each independently
B. only as a corporate body, and only at its edges / boundary conditions
C. never, since experience is irrelevant to belief
D. only through statements that are analytic

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Confirmation holism: the total field faces the tribunal of experience as a whole; only the periphery touches experience directly.

MCQ 11

"No statement is immune to revision" implies, for Quine, that:

- A. the laws of logic are the one exception and cannot be revised
B. only observation sentences are ever revisable
C. even the laws of logic could in principle be revised to conserve the rest of the system
D. only analytic truths are revisable

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Holism extends revisability to logic itself, though logic is surrendered only under great pressure, by minimum mutilation.

MCQ 12

The contrast between "central" and "peripheral" statements in the web is one of:

- A. truth versus falsity
B. analytic versus synthetic, now vindicated in Quine's own theory
C. meaningful versus meaningless
D. degree of entrenchment / distance from experience, not a difference of kind

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Centrality replaces the a priori/a posteriori split with a gradient of entrenchment, not a sharp boundary.

MCQ 13

From $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$ and an observed NOT-O, the Duhem-Quine point is that one may validly infer only:

- A. NOT-(H & A) - something in the package is false, but logic does not say which conjunct
B. NOT-H specifically
C. NOT-A specifically
D. that both H and A are confirmed

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Modus tollens condemns the conjunction, leaving open which member to revise; that is why refutation is never decisive against one sentence.

MCQ 14

How do Duhem's and Quine's versions of the thesis differ?

A. They are identical in scope and content B. Duhem restricts it to theoretical physics and exempts logic/mathematics, whereas Quine extends it to the whole of science, logic included C. Quine restricts it to physics while Duhem extends it to all knowledge D. Both explicitly exempt logic and mathematics

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Scope is the key difference; Quine's extension to logic is the controversial step that drives the analytic/synthetic collapse.

MCQ 15

The Neptune and Vulcan episodes together illustrate that:

A. revising an auxiliary is always the correct response to an anomaly B. revising the deep law is always the correct response C. the same logical situation can be correctly met by revising an auxiliary (Uranus -> Neptune) or by revising the deep law (Mercury -> general relativity), with no rule fixing which in advance D. Newtonian mechanics is in principle unrevisable

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Neptune vindicated auxiliary revision; Vulcan failed and the correct fix was general relativity - opposite responses, identical logic.

MCQ 16

Popper's response to the Duhem-Quine point is best described as:

A. a flat denial of the logical point B. an embrace of sceptical relativism about science C. a reduction of scientific method to individual psychology D. accepting the logic but treating falsification as a methodological decision that forbids ad hoc rescues

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Popper concedes the logic and adds methodological rules; Lakatos develops this into hard core / protective belt research programmes.

MCQ 17

In the "Gavagai" scenario, why can the field linguist not settle whether the term means "rabbit" or "undetached rabbit-parts"?

A. Both translations fit the same stimulus meaning, and distinguishing them needs the native's apparatus of individuation (identity predicate, articles, plurals), which is itself undetermined B. The native speaker deliberately refuses to cooperate C. Rabbits move too quickly to be observed reliably D. The linguist lacks a bilingual dictionary

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The rival translations share stimulus meaning; the "same gavagai?" question presupposes the very individuation apparatus under investigation.

MCQ 18

"Inscrutability of reference" and "indeterminacy of translation" are related in that:

A. they are simply two names for one identical claim B. inscrutability of reference (of terms) supports the broader indeterminacy of translation (of whole manuals of analytical hypotheses) C. they are logically opposed to each other D. both deny that stimulus meaning exists at all

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Reference of sub-sentential terms is undetermined; rival analytical hypotheses generate whole manuals with no fact of the matter between them.

MCQ 19

Which premise does Quine himself acknowledge as driving the indeterminacy argument in the special case of language?

- A. rationalism about innate meanings B. Cartesian substance dualism C. behaviourism about the evidence for meaning - in linguistics, he says, "one has no choice" D. acceptance of the analytic/synthetic distinction

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The evidence for meaning is public verbal behaviour; the force of the argument tracks this behaviourist premise about evidence.

MCQ 20

Chomsky's objection to the indeterminacy of translation is that:

- A. meanings are Platonic abstract objects B. translation between languages is always fully determinate C. the notion of stimulus meaning is incoherent D. indeterminacy is merely the ordinary underdetermination of theory by evidence that also affects physics, so Quine owes a special argument for treating meaning worse than physical theory

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Chomsky assimilates it to normal underdetermination; the burden falls on Quine to justify the asymmetry he posits between physics and meaning.

MCQ 21

Quine's criterion of ontological commitment is captured in the slogan:

- A. "To be is to be the value of a bound variable" (from "On What There Is", 1948) B. "To be is to be perceived" C. "The meaning of a word is its use" D. "Existence is a real predicate"

Correct answer: A

Explanation: A theory is committed to the entities its bound variables must range over; note the slogan is from "On What There Is" (1948), not "Two Dogmas" (1951).

MCQ 22

"Naturalized epistemology" is Quine's proposal that:

- A. epistemology is really a branch of ethics B. epistemology becomes continuous with empirical science - in effect "a chapter of psychology" - abandoning the search for an a priori foundation C. knowledge is impossible and scepticism wins D. only a priori methods can yield genuine knowledge

Correct answer: B

Explanation: From "Epistemology Naturalized" (1968/69): philosophy is continuous with science, not its prior tribunal; study how sensory input yields theory.

MCQ 23

"Ontological relativity" is the thesis that:

- A. every ontology whatsoever is equally false B. ontology is fixed absolutely by the laws of logic alone C. what a theory is "about" (the reference of its terms) is determinate only relative to a background language or translation manual D. there are, strictly speaking, no objects at all

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Reference is relative to a background manual; "at home" we acquiesce in our mother tongue and take it at face value.

MCQ 24

The convergence between Quine and the later Wittgenstein is best stated as:

A. both defend the analytic/synthetic distinction B. both are epistemological foundationalists C. both accept private ostensive definition of sensations D. despite different methods, both reject determinate private meanings (the "museum myth"), Quine via indeterminacy and Wittgenstein via meaning-as-use

Correct answer: D

Explanation: They converge on anti-private-meaning holism, though Quine reforms language (regimentation) while Wittgenstein describes it ("in order as it is").

MCQ 25

For Strawson, a "basic particular" is one that:

A. can be identified without first identifying any other particular B. is metaphysically simple, indivisible and indestructible C. is a private sense-datum given in immediate experience D. exists of absolute necessity

Correct answer: A

Explanation: "Basic" is a claim of identification-independence (conceptual dependence), not of simplicity or necessity.

MCQ 26

Strawson's argument that material bodies are basic turns crucially on:

A. their causal powers to affect the senses B. the requirement that objective thought allow re-identification, which needs a single unified spatio-temporal system that material bodies constitute C. their being the objects most directly perceived D. their infinite divisibility

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Re-identification ("the same one again") requires one public space-time, and bodies are what compose that framework.

MCQ 27

The "no-space" (purely auditory) world thought experiment is designed to show that:

A. sounds are themselves the basic particulars B. objective experience of any kind is impossible C. re-identification without space is possible only by constructing a space-analogue, which concedes that a spatio-temporal framework is required D. space is merely a subjective illusion

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The auditory world can support re-identification only by reintroducing a space-substitute (the "master-sound"), which supports Strawson's thesis.

MCQ 28

"Descriptive" as opposed to "revisionary" metaphysics is best defined as metaphysics that:

A. rejects metaphysics and conceptual analysis altogether B. constructs an ideal logical language to replace ordinary speech C. revises ordinary concepts to suit the needs of natural science D. lays bare the actual structure of our conceptual scheme rather than proposing a better one

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley are revisionary; Strawson (with Aristotle and Kant) is descriptive - Individuals (1959).

MCQ 29

To call the concept of a person "primitive" is to hold that it is:

- A. not analysable into the concept of a pure ego plus that of a body, but logically prior to both
- B. vague, pre-scientific and destined to be replaced
- C. innate and present in the mind from birth
- D. identical with the concept of a living biological organism

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Primitive = unanalysable into mind + body; those concepts are later abstractions from the person concept.

MCQ 30

P-predicates differ from M-predicates in that P-predicates are:

- A. applicable only to inanimate material bodies
- B. ascribed to others on the basis of behavioural criteria but to oneself without observation
- C. always confined to weight and spatial location
- D. never ascribable to oneself at all

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The asymmetry of ascription (others by behaviour, self without observation) is the defining mark of a P-predicate.

MCQ 31

The core premise of Strawson's argument for the primitiveness of the person is that:

- A. the body causally produces the mind
- B. experiences are strictly unowned events
- C. self-ascription of P-predicates is possible only if one can also ascribe them to others
- D. only one's own mind can ever be known

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Self-ascription requires other-ascription, which requires identifying others as single subjects of both M- and P-predicates.

MCQ 32

Strawson refutes the "no-ownership" theory by arguing that it:

- A. contradicts the findings of empirical neuroscience
- B. is incompatible with substance dualism
- C. cannot be verified by observation
- D. cannot state the contingent dependence of experiences on a body without covertly using "my", thereby reintroducing the ownership it denies

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The theory is self-refuting: "my experiences" cannot be eliminated, so experiences are necessarily owned by a person.

MCQ 33

In "On Referring" (1950), Strawson's central objection to Russell is that Russell:

- A. conflates the meaning of a sentence with the act of referring, treating the sentence itself as what refers
- B. denies that definite descriptions exist
- C. already accepts truth-value gaps
- D. rejects the use of formal logic altogether

Correct answer: A

Explanation: For Strawson people (not sentences) refer, in a use on an occasion; sentence meaning is a set of rules for such use.

MCQ 34

On Strawson's account, "The present King of France is bald" (there being no such king) is:

- A. straightforwardly true
- B. neither true nor false, because a presupposition of the referring use fails
- C. false, because the sentence asserts a uniquely existing king and that fails
- D. literally meaningless

Correct answer: B

Explanation: A failed presupposition yields a truth-value gap, not a falsehood - the sharp contrast with Russell.

MCQ 35

For Russell's Theory of Descriptions ("On Denoting", 1905), the same empty-subject sentence is:

- A. neither true nor false
- B. true by default
- C. false, because it asserts (and fails) that exactly one King of France exists
- D. a case of presupposition failure

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Russell analyses "the" as a quantifier asserting unique existence; with no such king the whole statement is false.

MCQ 36

Strawson counts as a "critic of empiricism" (the syllabus phrase) chiefly because he argues that:

- A. empiricism is excessively mathematical
- B. sense-data are the only reality there is
- C. inductive inference is deductively valid
- D. identification of any particular presupposes a public spatio-temporal framework, so the private sense-datum cannot be the basic given

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Strawson attacks empiricism's starting point (the private given), a critique at a different level from Quine's internal reform.

MCQ 37

The central disagreement between Quine and Strawson is best framed as whether the conceptual scheme is:

- A. holistically revisable "come what may" (Quine) or an indispensable precondition of objective thought (Strawson)
- B. true or false as a whole
- C. expressible in first-order logic
- D. compatible with the existence of God

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Revisable web versus indispensable framework is the standing tension the examiner most often probes.

MCQ 38

Which of the following is a genuine convergence between Quine and Strawson?

- A. Both accept a robust analytic/synthetic distinction
- B. Both reject a private inner object as the anchor of meaning, making the public / holistic basic
- C. Both are revisionary metaphysicians building ideal languages
- D. Both deny that experience constrains belief in any way

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Quine's behaviourism about meaning and Strawson's public criteria for P-predicates both reject the private given as the anchor of meaning.

MCQ 39

Treating Quine and Strawson as "basically agreeing" is a trap because they in fact differ on:

- A. nothing of philosophical importance
- B. matters of terminology only
- C. the status of the scheme (revisable vs precondition), the nature of meaning (indeterminate vs publicly fixed) and method (naturalist vs descriptive)
- D. whether persons exist at all

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Their convergence is in target and temper, not doctrine; the substantive differences remain sharp.

MCQ 40

The recommended "graded" closing position on the revisable-versus-indispensable question is that:

- A. the scheme is wholly and uniformly revisable
- B. the scheme is wholly fixed and unrevisable
- C. the question itself is meaningless
- D. the periphery is Quineanly revisable, but some framework role (a public world, re-identifiable subjects) looks Strawsonianly indispensable - so the truth is layered

Correct answer: D

Explanation: A layered verdict captures what survives on each side rather than forcing an all-or-nothing choice.

Remedial MCQ 41

Which attribution observes correct provenance discipline?

- A. "To be is to be the value of a bound variable" is from "On What There Is" (1948), not "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951)
- B. The bound-variable slogan first appears in "Two Dogmas" (1951)
- C. Quantum logic was proposed jointly by Putnam and Birkhoff in 1936
- D. Duhem himself extended the underdetermination thesis to all knowledge, including logic

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Provenance: the ontological-commitment slogan is 1948; quantum logic is Birkhoff & von Neumann (1936), pressed as empirical revision by Putnam (1968); Duhem restricted his thesis to physics.

Remedial MCQ 42

A common error states Quine's conclusion as "no sentence is really analytic." The accurate statement is that:

- A. all sentences turn out to be synthetic
- B. there is no principled, non-circular criterion for analyticity, though familiar sentences may still appear analytic
- C. analytic sentences are all false
- D. analyticity just is necessity by definition

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Quine denies a principled boundary, not the appearance of analyticity; the over-strong reading loses marks.

Remedial MCQ 43

Davidson's "Radical Interpretation" (1973) is often confused with Quine's project. Correctly, it:

- A. is identical to Quine's radical translation
- B. rejects indeterminacy of meaning entirely
- C. is interpretation (not translation) and treats residual indeterminacy as harmless, like a choice between Fahrenheit and Celsius
- D. denies that meaning is public at all

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Note the term "interpretation"; Davidson accepts indeterminacy but domesticates it to something like a choice of measurement scale.

Remedial MCQ 44

A frequent mistake is to call Strawson's descriptive metaphysics "anti-metaphysical." Correctly, it:

A. rejects all conceptual analysis B. constructs an ideal logical language C. denies that persons exist D. is itself metaphysics - it describes the actual structure of our conceptual scheme instead of revising it

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Descriptive versus revisionary is a contrast within metaphysics, not a rejection of it.

Remedial MCQ 45

"In Defence of a Dogma" (1956), which defends the analytic/synthetic distinction against Quine, was written by:

A. H. P. Grice and P. F. Strawson B. Strawson alone C. Quine and Carnap D. Russell and Strawson

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The paper is co-authored by Grice and Strawson; do not attribute it to Strawson alone.

Remedial MCQ 46

Strawson's use of behavioural criteria for P-predicates commits him to the view that:

A. P-predicates simply mean patterns of behaviour (logical behaviourism) B. behaviour is criterial evidence for P-predicates, not their meaning C. the mental should be eliminated from the account D. Cartesian dualism is correct after all

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Strawson insists P-predicates are not reducible to behaviour; behaviour is criterial, not definitional - so he is not a logical behaviourist.

Remedial MCQ 47

On the empty-subject sentence, the Russell/Strawson split is correctly stated as:

A. both hold it is neither true nor false B. both hold it is false C. Russell holds it is false (unique existence asserted and fails); Strawson holds it is neither true nor false (a presupposition fails) D. Russell holds it is true; Strawson holds it is false

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The verdicts diverge precisely on falsity (Russell) versus a truth-value gap (Strawson).

Remedial MCQ 48

Which question should NOT be counted as owned by "Quine and Strawson", despite conceptual overlap?

A. a question on Strawson's theory of persons B. a question on Quine's web of belief and holism C. a question on Strawson's basic particulars D. a question owned primarily by Kant on the defence of the synthetic a priori

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Ownership discipline keeps Logical Positivism, Empiricism and Kant questions separate even where they overlap Quine's critique of empiricism.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1

Original 10-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Quine and Strawson | Answer in about 150 words

Question: Explain how Quine's confirmation holism follows from his rejection of the two dogmas of empiricism.

Model solution

Thesis. Confirmation holism is the positive residue that remains once both dogmas are removed: with no analytic/synthetic line and no individual verification, belief can face experience only as a whole.

Argument. Dogma 1 fails because "analytic" has no non-circular criterion (synonymy, definition, interchangeability *salva veritate*, necessity, semantic rules all presuppose it). Dogma 2 fails because, by the Duhem-Quine point, a hypothesis implies an observation only with auxiliaries: $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$, so a failed prediction condemns the package, not one sentence. Removing individual verification leaves the **web of belief** meeting "the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body"; hence no statement is immune to revision.

Verdict. Holism is not an extra assumption but the direct consequence of denying that sentences have private confirmation-conditions - "empiricism without the dogmas".

Why this earns marks: it derives holism rather than asserting it, using the exact mechanism and 1951 source.

Original Mains 2

Original 15-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Quine and Strawson | Answer in about 250 words

Question: "Strawson's persons and Quine's web of belief are two forms of one anti-Cartesian conviction." Critically discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. The claim is largely true at the level of *temper* - both make the public, not a private inner object, the anchor of thought - but it overstates the case if read as doctrinal identity, for the two differ on the status of the conceptual scheme.

The convergence. Strawson's persons are single subjects of P-predicates ascribed to others on **public behavioural criteria**; the private Cartesian ego is rejected as the bearer of meaning. Quine's **web of belief**, resting on behaviourism about the evidence for meaning, likewise denies determinate private meanings (the "museum myth"). Both thus reject the private given: Strawson replaces the private sense-datum with a public spatio-temporal framework, Quine replaces sentence-by-sentence private confirmation with a holistic public science. Each is, in the syllabus phrase, a critic of empiricism's private starting point.

The divergence (critical). But the "one conviction" reading hides three differences. (i) *Status*: for Quine the scheme is holistically **revisable** come what may; for Strawson the framework (a public world, re-identifiable subjects, persons) is an **indispensable precondition** of objective thought. (ii) *Meaning*: Quine's is behaviourally **indeterminate**; Strawson's is **fixed** by public criteria. (iii) *Method*: naturalism versus descriptive-transcendental metaphysics.

Verdict. The anti-Cartesian, anti-private-object conviction is genuinely shared, and naming it shows synoptic command; but the deeper truth is layered - the periphery of the scheme is Quineanly revisable while some framework role looks Strawsonianly indispensable. So the sentence is a real insight, not an identity.

Why this earns marks: it affirms the convergence with exact mechanisms, then critically separates status, meaning and method, closing on a graded verdict.

Original Mains 3

Original 20-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Quine and Strawson | Answer in about 250 words

Question: Assess the claim that both Quine and Strawson refute classical empiricism, but at different levels.

Model solution

Thesis. Both are critics of classical empiricism, but Quine reforms it from *within* its theory of confirmation, whereas Strawson challenges its *starting point*; the two critiques are complementary, and together they leave little of the classical picture standing.

Quine's internal critique. Classical empiricism rests on two dogmas: a sharp **analytic/synthetic** distinction and **reductionism** (each statement has its own confirming experiences). Quine dismantles both - analyticity has no non-circular criterion, and by the **Duhem-Quine** point no statement is confirmed in isolation. The result is **confirmation holism**: the **web of belief** faces experience as a corporate body, so "no statement is immune to revision". Crucially Quine *retains* empiricism - experience is still the only check on belief - so his is a reform, "empiricism without the dogmas", not a rejection.

Strawson's external critique. Classical empiricism also assumes the **given** is **private, atomic sense-data** from which the public world is constructed. Strawson reverses the dependence: identification and **re-identification** of any particular presuppose a single **public spatio-temporal framework** of **basic particulars** - material bodies and persons. The private sense-datum is not self-standing but is itself identified only by reference to the public world and its owner. So the empiricist *starting point* is incoherent as a foundation.

Assessment. The critiques operate at different levels - theory of confirmation versus theory of the given - and are mutually reinforcing: Quine removes the epistemic scaffolding, Strawson removes the foundation. **Objection:** Grice and Strawson resist Quine's overreach on analyticity, and a defender of sense-data may deny that identification needs a public framework. **Reply:** even granting these, the burden has shifted decisively onto the empiricist.

Verdict. Empiricism survives only as Quine's holistic, dogma-free version; the classical private-atomistic form is refuted at both levels.

Why this earns marks: it distinguishes the two levels precisely, gives each thinker's exact mechanism, weighs a named objection, and returns a clear graded verdict.